Net 'connector' has skeptic's wiring

■ CYBERLINKS

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within minutes, she's deep in a discussion with a woman who represents a health-oriented Web site. The next thing you know, Brown has the woman's business card. The contact may come in handy some day.

"I'm an Aquarius," she says. "Humanity is my thing."

Brown is one of those individuals that author Malcolm Gladwell describes as a "connector," a walking, talking Rolodex of sorts who makes it her business to bring other people together. And for the past five years, she's been doing her matchmaking on the Internet. Using the online monikers of Sistah Geek and Miss D.C., Brown runs Black Geeks Online from her home in Washington. Founded on a whim in 1996, the loose-knit organization has grown from 18 members to 25,000 today, and Brown has established herself as an unofficial Internet griot who sends out missives to members all over the world, from the South Bronx to South Africa. The organization is a digital grapevine for people of color online, and Brown has made it her mission to encourage black information tech professionals to volunteer in the community.

"She has a genius for knowing all the right people," says Adam Fisher, senior associate editor of Wired magazine. "She makes things happen." Brown has adopted Fisher as her "new best friend;" she feeds him tips about black high-tech entrepreneurs to feature in the magazine.

The 57-year-old grandmother, however, is the first to admit that she is an unlikely role model for budding geeks. A sixth-generation Washingtonian, she dropped out of college after six months – "I didn't like it. They told you to read the book and spit it out" – and spent several decades working as a secretary in the civil service. Back in her day, the transistor radio was considered high-tech. But her brother, a retired computer engineer, introduced her to the Internet in 1994. She resisted at first – "I said, 'Oh, no, you don't. Big Brother will not get me!'" – but when she discovered that she could exchange recipes with a chef in New Orleans, she was hooked. "I'm a communicator, an information broker, and I saw the potential," she recalls.

Since she founded Black Geeks in her living room four years ago, she has organized an information technology workshop called "Taking IT to the Streets," which introduced 200 newbies to computers and the Internet. Earlier this year, she was tapped as one of the Top 25 Women on the Web by SFWoW, a San Francisco-based association of professional women involved in the Internet. Brown, who is known for wearing red high-tops and a Tweety Bird watch, shared the honors with top CEOs and computer scientists. "She isn't your typical CEO, but she has made a difference by helping other women get over their fear of the Internet," says Mary Choy, who ran the committee that selected this year's winners. "When she accepted her award, she said, 'They told me not to wear sneakers and not to curse onstage, but here I am, wearing sneakers and cursing onstage.' She fit in beautifully."

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Brown chooses not to wear those red high-tops for her appearance at Harvard, though. "A girl has to look her best," she says with a coy smile. But she is going to speak her mind. She is frequently asked to speak about the digital divide, the gap between the technology haves and have-nots. The digital divide is usually described as a gap between blacks and whites, but Brown isn't convinced that the problem can easily be solved by throwing money and computers at poor communities. "My main concern, from [Vice President Al] Gore to [Microsoft chairman Bill] Gates, is that all this equipment and money is being handed out in a vacuum," she says. "They're putting computers in the schools without talking to the parents or the community. None of this money is going to train people. They're just creating new consumers, and the last thing poor people need to do is to find a new electronic mall."

Brown, like many other former Internet enthusiasts, no longer thinks that computers in and of themselves can provide the answer to society's ills. "I'm a techno realist," she says. "It's time to stop and say, 'Wait a minute.'"

And she is willing to stir up debate wherever she goes. At the Harvard conference, which was called Internet and Society 2000, she objects when a moderator wants to discuss the digital divide in the Third World. "I don't see how we can fix someone else's barn when ours is falling to the ground," she says. When she goes through her spiel about the Internet dehumanizing society, including the bit about the coffee, the crowd applauds.

"Anita is a '60s revolutionary who uses the Internet as a new tool to kind of continue the philosophy and ideology of changing things and not accepting the status quo," says Kenny Granderson, a fellow panelist and the founder of Inner City Software in Dorchester. Granderson is a kindred spirit. He founded Boston Blacks Online, a group of 650 members who communicate on the Internet. "We both deal with people on a grass-roots level, dealing with the regular Joes and Janes," Granderson says.

Indeed, after a few days in Cambridge, Brown connects with many Joes and Janes and counts a number of "new best friends." After her appearance on the panel, she launches an animated conversation with José Orlando López, vice president for academic affairs and innovations at the American University of Puerto Rico. She takes his card, one more for her Rolodex. You never know when Sistah Geek might need a best friend in Puerto Rico.

Book Review

A storyteller weaves the tale of his racy life orbiting stars

By Bruce McCabe
GLOBE STAFF

ORIGINAL STORY BY
A Memoir of Broadway and Hollywood
By Arthur Laurents
Knopf, 438 pp., illustrated, $30

Sex – his preferences and others', and denials of same – is a leitmotif of Arthur Laurents's memoir, and it's understandable. Sex and sexual politics permeate the show business milieu that he inhabited for so long, as a director and a writer of plays and movies. You live and breathe it, and big decisions are based on it – probably more than those outside the business realize.

Still, as befits a successful dramatic writer, Laurents is too good a storyteller to get sidetracked from his story line, the "arc" of which chronicles his odyssey from a boyhood in Flatbush to coming of age in college and the Army to his varied experiences writing for radio, theater, and the movies. His experiences brought him into contact with an assortment of legends. He seems to have a telling anecdote about everyone from Alfred Hitchcock and Katharine Hepburn to David Lean and Barbra Streisand. A fair number of these legends turn out to be wily, treacherous, insecure, disagreeable, and – worst of all – less talented than legend has it.

Along the way, Laurents also settles scores with what he calls "unrepentant homophobes" and anti-Semites. Gloria Jones, widow of novelist James Jones, was one of the former, he says, who congratulated him for his writing of women. (Laurents's reaction: "Wasted point: it's men that homosexual men can have trouble writing.") An anti-Semite was a professor of playwriting at Cornell who would start sentences with "you Jews" – there were two others besides Laurents in the class. The professor's first instruction to the class was a ukase: Never begin a play with a telephone ringing. Laurents immediately wrote a one-act play that began with a telephone ringing.

A particular object of Laurents's disaffection is choreographer Jerome Robbins, a "monster" with whom he collaborated on the musicals "West Side Story" and "Gypsy." Another figure is movie director Sidney Pollack, with whom Laurents worked as screenwriter of the movie "The Way We Were." Laurents writes that Pollack sacrificed a good movie to keep Robert Redford happy.

There are enough gibes and lines to keep the devotee of behind-the-scenes stories interested. Producer Ray Stark "worked overtime at the job he wanted: casting young actresses." A rival for Laurents's affections is described as an "assisted blonde." On playwright William Inge: "His work made him seem a very sensitive man; which he was – to himself. He didn't understand what it was to be a friend."

There are three wonderfully bitchy descriptions on one page alone. Stripper Gypsy Rose Lee "hadn't a good body but she was smart enough not to expose it." Robbins "was the rock and the hard place." An actress playing Gypsy "looked virginal even though she was going through the orchestra like a dose of salts." Fortunately, Laurents's best lines are usually dryer than that one. Consider an observation that recurred in Sardi's restaurant whenever Moss Hart, not known for his interest in marriage, would appear with a woman: "Ah, here comes Moss Hart with the future Miss Edith Atwater."

There are plenty of inside looks. One of Leonard Bernstein's problems: he "wasn't housebroken." Here's Gypsy's mother's trenchant advice to her daughter who's facing her first audience of men: "Make 'em

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BOSTON GLOBE MOVIE DIRECTORY

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ALLSTON CINEMAS
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214 Harvard Ave. 617-277-2140
♿ ( ) DOL
Purchase Tickets Online @ Movietickets.com
www.national-amusements.com
SHANGHAI NOON (PG-13) (12:45, 3:00, 5:15) 7:30, 10:00, 12:20
ROAD TRIP (R) (12:00, 2:30, 5:00) 7:40, 10:10, 12:30

★ ARLINGTON ★

CAPITOL THEATRE
234 Mass. Ave. 781-648-4340
ROAD TRIP (R) 11:35, 1:35, 3:35, 5:35, 7:35, 9:35
BOSSA NOVA (R) 11:30, 1:30, 3:30, 5:30, 7:25, 9:45
UP AT THE VILLA (PG-13) 11:55, 2:25, 4:50, 7:15, 9:40
ERIN BROCKOVICH (R) 11:45, 2:20, 5:00, 7:20, 10:00
U-571 (PG-13) 12:15, 2:45, 5:10, 7:40, 10:05
▼THE CIDER HOUSE RULES (PG-13) 5:05, 7:30, 9:55
THE FLINTSTONES IN VIVA ROCK VEGAS (PG) 11:25, 1:20, 3:15

★ BOSTON ★ CIRCLE CINEMAS · ★ BELLINGHAM ★ HOYTS CINEMAS BELLINGHAM CINEMA 14 · ★ BURLINGTON ★ General Cinema BURLINGTON CINEMA 10 · ★ CAMBRIDGE ★ Landmark's KENDALL SQUARE · ★ DEDHAM ★ SHOWCASE CINEMAS

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